went by road to Jhalawar.

But Raje does have her share of hurdles. The huge welcome for her in Bikaner was organised by local heavyweights, including ex-royal and MLA Siddhi Kumari and former BJP veteran Devi Singh Bhatti. Bhatti had left the party in 2019 to protest Meghwal being allotted the Bikaner Lok Sabha seat, after accusing him of sabotaging the elections of a few BJP candidates in the assembly election. Fearing that Raje may push for getting Bhatti back into the BJP, Poonia has set up a panel to decide which rebels can be reinducted and made Meghwal in charge of it.

Poonia's open anti-Raje stand has made her loyalists—and these include nearly two-thirds of the party MLAs—certain that with him around, the party could lose the next election. Even some of Raje's staunch critics admit that as state president, Poonia has been unable to explain the party's poor performance in elections to local bodies and even the assembly bypolls. Critics say that as of now, the state unit will have to rely on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's charisma to win them the next assembly election, which is due by December 2023.

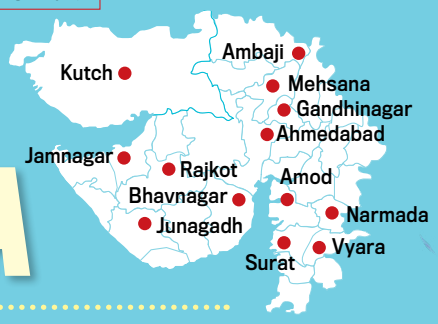
IN RAJE'S ABSENCE, TWO BIG RIVALS WERE THROWING A CHALLENGE IN HER DEN, JHALAWAR-BARAN

But Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah are yet to give Raje the go-ahead. Sources say the high command may accede to her becoming chief minister, given that she is the leader most feared by rivals in the state. But she might be asked to step down halfway through the term to make way for someone like Birla or Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, the Union minister for Jal Shakti who is among the leaders the BJP has been assessing as a possible CM candidate.

During her visit to Deshnok temple near Bikaner, Raje was witness to a good omen—a white rat. The ex-maharani of Dholpur is 69 and probably fighting her last major political battle to lead the party to power and become chief minister for a third time. But it's early days yet. She'll have to quell many a rival, inside and outside the party, to get to the finish line. ■

GUJARAT/ ASSEMBLY ELECTION

SOP OPERA



AUGUST 27-28, 2022

KUTCH

Projects worth: *Rs 7,000 crore*

- The 357-km Kutch branch canal of Sardar Sarovar project to provide water for irrigation to 182 villages and drinking water to 948 villages and 10 towns in Kutch
- Smriti Van memorial and earthquake museum in Bhuj

Eye on polls: PM Narendra Modi has often talked about making water from Sardar Sarovar reach each village in Gujarat. The canal project helps the BJP project him as a 'man of his word'

SEPTEMBER 28-30

AMBAJI, BANASKANTHA

Projects worth: *Rs 7,200 crore*

- Two new sections of Western Dedicated Freight Corridor from New Palanpur
- Financial aid to *gaushalas*; development of pilgrimage facilities at Ambaji temple

Eye on polls: The BJP wants to further strengthen its base in North Gujarat. The aid to *gaushalas* is an attempt to pacify the Maldhari community, upset over restrictions on cattle grazing

AHMEDABAD AND GANDHINAGAR

Projects worth: *Rs 12,900 crore*

- Phase 1 of Ahmedabad Metro to connect the eastern and western parts of the city
- Vande Bharat Express, a superfast train between Gandhinagar and Mumbai Central, flagged off

Eye on polls: Urban voters have been the BJP's strength. It is making efforts to retain their support amid resentment over inflation

SURAT

Projects worth: *Rs 3,400 crore*

- Phase 1 of Diamond Research and Mercantile (DREAM) City
- New museum at Science City; biodiversity park to come up over 87 hectares

Eye on polls: Surat, the 'diamond city', is where AAP made its first inroads in the 2017 municipal polls. As AAP now concentrates its efforts on the district's 16 assembly seats, the BJP's best bet is netting the diamond traders

BHAVNAGAR, SAURASHTRA

Projects worth: *Rs 5,200 crore*

- The world's first CNG terminal and a brownfield port to be developed at a cost of Rs 4,000 crore

Eye on polls: Saurashtra has been the BJP's weakest link, though Bhavnagar city has been its stronghold. The new projects might help it garner votes in rural areas